

SHARP SHOOTER

Wildlife photography is not just a passion for Vivek Sunder, CEO of Cuemath, but also helps him become a better business leader

BY SMITA TRIPATHI

In 2020, just before the world went into lockdown, Vivek Sunder was in Masai Mara, Kenya, on a wildlife photography shoot. His subject was a cheetah chasing a gazelle. “It’s very difficult to photograph a cheetah running towards you. Every time you lock the focus, it’s so fast that it comes another few metres towards you,” explains the 48-year-old CEO of edtech company Cuemath. After observing the cheetah for a couple of hours, Sunder was able to anticipate its path. “I then focussed on a flower in its way. My idea was to click when it came closest to the flower and then hope for the best. After some 40 tries I finally got a shot where the entire body was in focus except for the tail which was swishing back and forth.” Sunder won second place in a *National Geographic* competition for that picture.

Sunder’s tryst with photography started quite by chance when his wife gifted him a Canon DSLR camera for his 40th birthday. While for the first year he used it only on auto mode, he soon enrolled in a photography course by Bengaluru-based Toehold. Having learnt the ropes, Sunder was itching to start shooting but there isn’t “much wildlife in Bombay” so he shot portraits and architecture. As luck would have it, he soon moved to Nairobi as P&G’s CEO in East Africa. “I was 45 minutes flying time away from the Masai Mara. It was there that I started photography seriously.”

Sunder, who has been with Cuemath since October 2021, says photography is immensely useful as it has provided him with skills that come in handy in business as well. “For one, it improves your concentration. Two, you become more adept at observing things. For instance, my advertising agency guys keep complaining that I notice so many things. Thanks to photography, I

READY FOR ACTION Sunder’s image of a cheetah chasing a gazelle won him a prize in a *National Geographic* contest

